HOW A GENERATOR MAKES ELECTRICITY

Almost every power plant ends the same way: a spinning magnet inside a coil of copper.

1

SPIN

Steam, hot gas, an engine, water or wind turns a shaft.

2

MAGNET IN A COIL

The shaft spins a magnet (the rotor) inside copper windings (the stator).

3

CURRENT

The moving magnetic field pushes current through the copper: alternating current, 60 times a second.

60 Hz

US grid frequency: every generator on it spins in step

3,600 rpm

a two-pole gas or steam turbine generator at 60 Hz

21 kV

SW-3X1's generators; the step-up transformer lifts it to 230 kV

Copper

the windings, the bus, the cable: all of it carries the current out

Solar panels, fuel cells and batteries are the exceptions: they make DC, and an inverter turns it into 60 Hz AC for the grid.

FROM THE GENERATOR TO THE LIGHT SWITCH

Power is made at medium voltage, raised to high voltage to travel, then stepped down again near the customer.

1

GENERATOR

13.8–25 kV

21 kV in SW-3X1

CABLE

isolated-phase bus, MV-105

›

2

STEP-UP (GSU)

→ 115–765 kV

230 kV in SW-3X1

CABLE

HV XLPE cable, switchyard bus

›

3

TRANSMISSION

115–765 kV

long distance, overhead

CABLE

overhead conductor, OPGW

›

4

SUBSTATION

→ 4–35 kV

steps it down for the town

CABLE

substation cable, grounding

›

5

DISTRIBUTION

4–35 kV

feeders along the streets

CABLE

MV URD, overhead distribution

›

6

CUSTOMER

480 / 240 / 120 V

factory, office, home

CABLE

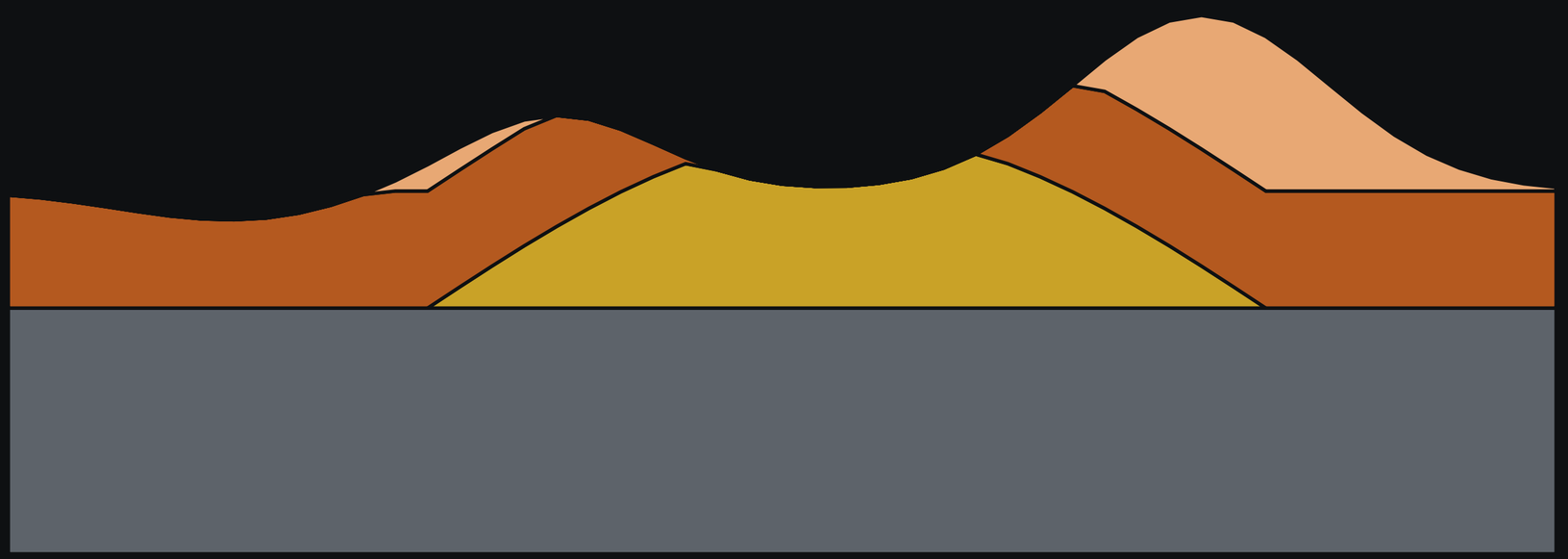
building wire, MC, service entrance

← INSIDE THE PLANT: TODAY

Higher voltage, lower current, smaller losses: that is why transmission runs at hundreds of kV. Southwire has a product family at every step, from the generator to the outlet.

A DAY ON THE GRID: WHO RUNS WHEN

Demand rises in the morning and peaks in the evening. Each kind of plant takes a layer.



- Peaking: simple cycle, engines, batteries
- Mid-merit: combined cycle
- Solar
- Baseload: nuclear, coal, combined cycle

The evening peak arrives as the sun sets: that is when gas and batteries earn their keep.

Illustrative summer weekday, not a real grid's data.

> **Every start and stop cycles the plant**, and its cable: heat, vibration and terminations that move. Peakers may start every day.

FRONT OF THE METER, BEHIND THE METER

The same machines, two business models. The meter is the line between the utility and the customer.

FRONT OF THE METER

THE UTILITY-SCALE PLANT

- Sells power into the grid through a switchyard and the POI
- Utilities and IPPs; the ISO dispatches it
- HV gen-tie, switchyard, GSUs: the big cables
- Most of SW-3X1's power block

BEHIND THE METER

POWER AT THE CUSTOMER'S SITE

- Feeds a load directly: data centre, factory, campus
- Often modular engines, turbines, fuel cells and batteries
- MV collection and LV distribution on site; little or no grid tie
- SW-3X1's data-centre campus and modular yard

Behind-the-meter is the fastest-growing lane: data centres that cannot wait years for a grid connection build their own power.

THE CABLE FAMILIES IN A POWER PLANT

From the biggest to the smallest. In SW-3X1's schedule: 21,217 cables, 1,212 miles.

HV — 69–345 kV
XLPE: switchyard and gen-tie

MV — 5–35 kV
MV-105: big motors, transformers, feeders

LV POWER — 600 V
TC-ER, MC, ARMOR-X: motors, panels, lighting

VFD — 600 V–2 kV
drive-rated: fans and pumps on drives

CONTROL — 600 V
TC-ER multi-conductor: breakers, valves, interlocks

INSTRUMENTATION — 300 V
PLTC / ITC shielded pairs, thermocouple extension

FIBRE — –
controls network, protection

GROUNDING — bare Cu
the ground grid under everything

By length: Instrumentation 44% · LV 600 V power 20% · Control 18% · Fibre, fire alarm, other 11% · MV / HV 7%. The big cables get the attention; the small ones make up most of the miles.

Shares by footage from the SW-3X1 model cable schedule; voltage ratings typical.

stephan.hardt@southwire.com

WHAT A POWER PLANT DOES TO A CABLE

STRESS	WHERE	THE ANSWER
HEAT	beside turbines, HRSGs and steam lines	high-temperature ratings, route away from hot surfaces
CYCLING	daily starts: heat, vibration, moving terminations	flexible strands, good terminations, support
ELECTRICAL NOISE	variable-frequency drives on fans and pumps	VFD-rated, shielded cable
HAZARDOUS AREAS	gas skids and fuel yards (Class I, Div 2)	ARMOR-X MC-HL, no conduit
FIRE AND SMOKE	halls, control rooms, cable spreading rooms	flame-retardant, low-smoke, circuit integrity
OUTDOORS	sun, oil, water, burial	sunlight- and oil-resistant jackets, direct-burial ratings
SCHEDULE	long pulls on the critical path	SIMpull reels, cut-to-length, pre-terminated

The wrong cable fails early, and a cable failure can trip a unit. That is why the spec is strict, and why it is written for each area of the plant.

stephan.hardt@southwire.com

GAS PLANTS ARE GETTING CLEANER, AND MORE CABLE-DENSE



HYDROGEN

- Gas turbines can burn a blend of hydrogen with natural gas; OEMs are working toward 100%
- Our model has an H2 receiving station, trailer bay and an electrolyzer building
- More gas-detection, hazardous-area and DC cable



CARBON CAPTURE

- Captures CO2 from the stack: absorber, stripper, compressors
- A second plant's worth of motors, drives and instruments beside the first
- In SW-3X1: the CCS zone, about 142 miles of cable



BATTERIES BESIDE GAS

- Batteries take the fast swings; gas runs for days
- PCS skids, MV collection, DC cable in trenches
- In SW-3X1: the battery yard, about 50 miles of cable

Every add-on is more cable: hydrogen, carbon capture and storage each bring their own motors, drives, sensors and controls.

UNITS THAT STICK: KW, MW, GW

1 kW

a microwave oven running

kilowatt = 1,000 watts

1 MW

a large store or a small factory

megawatt = 1,000 kW

1 GW

the average use of roughly 800,000 US homes

gigawatt = 1,000 MW

300–550 MW

one large modern gas turbine

the machines in our turbine hall

MW IS POWER

how hard something runs right now: the speedometer

MWH IS ENERGY

power × time: the odometer. 1 MW for 1 hour = 1 MWh

CAPACITY FACTOR

how much a plant actually makes vs. running flat out all year

A 1 GW data-centre campus uses as much power as a city. That is why data centres are pulling new gas plants forward.

Homes: EIA average US residential use, about 10,800 kWh a year (about 1.2 kW on average). Turbine size: typical large-frame H/J-class range.

stephan.hardt@southwire.com

THE WORDS YOU WILL HEAR TODAY

BESS	battery energy storage system
BOP	balance of plant: everything that is not the main machines
BTM	behind the meter: power at the customer's site
COD	commercial operation date: when the plant goes live
EPC	engineering, procurement and construction contractor: builds the plant, buys the cable
FID	final investment decision: the money is committed
GSU	generator step-up transformer
HRSG	heat recovery steam generator: the boiler behind each gas turbine
IPP	independent power producer
ISO / RTO	the grid operator that runs a power market (ERCOT, PJM, MISO)
MCC	motor control centre
POI	point of interconnection: where the plant meets the grid
PPA	power purchase agreement
RICE	reciprocating internal combustion engine: a big gas engine
SCR	selective catalytic reduction: cuts NOx in the HRSG
VFD	variable-frequency drive: controls motor speed

A handout version can go out with the recording.

stephan.hardt@southwire.com